

Word family: **nervous / nervously / nervousness / nerve / nerves**

Base word: nervous

Part of speech: adjective

Related forms:

nervous (adj.) — 緊張的；焦慮的；神經系統的

nervously (adv.) — 緊張地；不安地

nervousness (n.) — 緊張；焦慮

nerve (n.) — 神經；勇氣；膽量；厚臉皮

nerves (plural noun) — 神經；緊張情緒

Useful expressions / extensions:

feel nervous

be nervous about

be nervous of

nervous before doing something

nervous smile / laugh

nervous habit

nervous system

nervous breakdown

get on someone's nerves

lose your nerve

have the nerve to do something

a bundle of nerves

Meaning in this passage

> I was a bit **nervous** before she opened it, because it felt much more personal than the usual things I would buy.

Here, **nervous** means:

worried, tense, or slightly afraid because you are uncertain about what will happen — 緊張的；忐忑的；有點不安的

The speaker was waiting to see how the mother would react to a very personal gift.

中文翻譯：

老實說，在她打開之前，我其實有點**緊張 / 忐忑**，因為這份禮物比我平時買的東西私密和個人得多。

So here:

nervous = 因為不知道對方會有甚麼反應，而感到緊張和不安

1. **nervous (緊張的；不安的) — 緊張；忐忑**

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> I was a bit **nervous** before she opened it.

在她打開禮物之前，我有點**緊張**。

Practice 2

> She felt **nervous** before the interview.

面試前，她感到很**緊張**。

Practice 3

> I always get **nervous** when I have to speak in public.

每次要在公眾面前說話，我都會變得很**緊張**。

MCQ-ready definition:

nervous = 因為即將發生的事情、未知結果或壓力而感到緊張、不安或擔心

2. **be nervous about something — 對某事感到緊張 / 擔心**

Practice 1

> I'm **nervous about the exam**.

我對這次考試感到**緊張**。

Practice 2

> He was **nervous about meeting her parents**.

他對見她父母這件事感到**忐忑**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****be nervous about X = 因 X 的結果或可能發生的事情而感到緊張或擔心****

3. ****be nervous of someone/something — 害怕 / 對.....有戒心****

This is close to ****afraid of****, especially BrE.

Practice 1

> The child is ****nervous of large dogs****.

那個孩子對大型犬隻有點****害怕 / 戒心****。

Practice 2

> She is ****nervous of flying****.

她對坐飛機有點****害怕****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****be nervous of X = 對 X 感到不安、害怕或缺乏安全感****

4. ****nervous before doing something — 做某事前感到緊張****

Practice 1

> He was ****nervous before giving the speech****.

他在演講前很****緊張****。

Practice 2

> I felt ****nervous before opening the results****.

我在查看結果前感到很****忐忑****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****nervous before doing X = 在即將做某件重要、不確定或有壓力的事情前感到緊張****

5. **nervous smile / laugh** — 緊張的笑；不自然的笑

Practice 1

> She gave a **nervous smile**.

她露出一個**緊張的微笑**。

Practice 2

> He let out a **nervous laugh**.

他發出了一聲**尷尬而緊張的笑**。

MCQ-ready definition:

nervous smile/laugh = 因不安、尷尬或緊張而出現的笑容或笑聲

6. **nervous habit** — 緊張時的小動作；神經質習慣

Practice 1

> Biting her nails is a **nervous habit**.

咬指甲是她**緊張時的小習慣**。

Practice 2

> He taps his foot as a **nervous habit**.

他一緊張就會用腳打拍子，這是他的**緊張小動作**。

MCQ-ready definition:

nervous habit = 因焦慮或緊張而反覆出現的動作或行為

7. **nervous** (容易緊張的；神經質的) — 容易焦慮；容易受驚

This describes a person's general temperament, not one temporary moment.

Practice 1

> She has always been a **nervous person**.

她一向是個**容易緊張的人**。

Practice 2

> He's quite **nervous by nature**.

他天生比較**容易焦慮 / 容易緊張**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****nervous = 性格上容易擔心、焦慮、緊張或受驚****

8. **nervous animal — 容易受驚的動物**

Practice 1

> Horses can be **nervous animals**.

馬有時是很**容易受驚的動物**。

Practice 2

> The dog became **nervous** around strangers.

那隻狗見到陌生人時變得**不安 / 容易受驚**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****nervous = 對聲音、陌生人或環境變化容易產生害怕或不安反應****

9. **nervous system — 神經系統**

A completely different scientific sense.

Practice 1

> The brain is part of the **nervous system**.

大腦是**神經系統**的一部分。

Practice 2

> The disease affects the central **nervous system**.

這種疾病會影響**中樞神經系統**。

MCQ-ready definition:

nervous = relating to the nerves, brain, spinal cord, and the body's system for transmitting signals

中文：

與神經、腦部、脊髓及神經訊號傳遞系統有關的

10. **nervous tissue / nervous disorder — 神經組織 / 神經系統疾病**

Practice 1

> **Nervous tissue** carries electrical signals.

神經組織負責傳遞電訊號。

Practice 2

> The condition is classified as a **nervous disorder**.

這種情況被歸類為**神經系統疾病**。

MCQ-ready definition:

nervous + medical noun = relating to the body's nerve system rather than emotional anxiety

11. **nervously — 緊張地；不安地**

Practice 1

> She smiled **nervously**.

她**緊張地**笑了笑。

Practice 2

> He looked **nervously** at the clock.

他**不安地**看着時鐘。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****nervously = 以顯得緊張、不安或擔心的方式****

12. ****nervousness — 緊張；焦慮****

Practice 1

> Her ****nervousness**** disappeared after the first few minutes.

幾分鐘後，她的****緊張感****消失了。

Practice 2

> I could hear the ****nervousness**** in his voice.

我能從他的聲音中聽出他的****緊張****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****nervousness = 緊張、焦慮或不安的狀態****

13. ****nerves (緊張情緒) — 緊張；膽怯****

A very common plural noun use.

Practice 1

> My ****nerves**** were terrible before the interview.

面試前我****緊張得不得了****。

Practice 2

> She managed to control her ****nerves****.

她設法控制自己的****緊張情緒****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****nerves = 尤其在壓力情況下出現的緊張、焦慮或膽怯情緒****

14. ****a bundle of nerves — 緊張得不得了；非常焦慮****

Practice 1

> I was **a bundle of nerves** before the presentation.

簡報前我**緊張得不得了**。

Practice 2

> He was **a bundle of nerves** while waiting for the results.

等候結果時，他**非常焦慮不安**。

MCQ-ready definition:

a bundle of nerves = informal: 非常緊張、焦慮，整個人處於高度不安狀態

15. **nerve (神經) — 神經**

The physical noun from the same family.

Practice 1

> The injury damaged a **nerve** in his hand.

那次受傷損害了他手部的一條**神經**。

Practice 2

> The dentist may need to treat the **nerve** inside the tooth.

牙醫可能需要處理牙齒內的**神經**。

MCQ-ready definition:

nerve = 身體內負責在腦、脊髓和其他部位之間傳遞訊號的纖維

16. **nerve (勇氣 ; 膽量) — 勇氣 ; 膽量**

A major figurative sense.

Practice 1

> I finally found the **nerve** to ask the question.

我終於鼓起**勇氣**問那個問題。

Practice 2

> She didn't have the **nerve** to tell him the truth.

她沒有**膽量**把真相告訴他。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****nerve = 在令人害怕、尷尬或有壓力的情況下採取行動所需的勇氣****

17. **lose your nerve — 失去勇氣；臨陣退縮**

Practice 1

> He was going to jump, but he **lost his nerve**.

他本來打算跳下去，但最後**失去勇氣 / 退縮了**。

Practice 2

> Don't **lose your nerve** now.

現在不要**臨陣退縮**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****lose your nerve = 原本有勇氣做某事，但在最後關頭因害怕而不敢做****

18. **keep / hold your nerve — 保持冷靜和膽量**

Practice 1

> She **held her nerve** and finished the speech.

她**保持鎮定**，完成了演講。

Practice 2

> The player **kept his nerve** under pressure.

那名球員在壓力下仍然**保持冷靜和膽量**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****keep/hold your nerve = 在壓力或危險中保持冷靜，不因害怕而退縮****

19. ****have the nerve to do something — 竟有膽量 / 竟敢做某事****

Often critical.

Practice 1

> He ****had the nerve to complain**** after arriving an hour late.

他遲到一小時後竟然還****有臉投訴****。

Practice 2

> She ****had the nerve to ask for more money****.

她竟然****厚着臉皮要求更多錢****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****have the nerve to do X = 帶批評語氣，指某人竟敢做一件被認為無禮、大膽或不合理的事****

20. ****get on someone's nerves — 惹某人厭煩；令某人很煩躁****

Practice 1

> That constant noise is ****getting on my nerves****.

那些持續不斷的噪音真的****令我很煩躁****。

Practice 2

> His complaining ****gets on everyone's nerves****.

他不停投訴，****弄得大家都很煩****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****get on someone's nerves = 反覆令某人感到煩躁、惱火或受不了****

21. **nervous breakdown** — 精神崩潰

A common informal/non-technical expression.

Practice 1

> He took time off work after a **nervous breakdown**.

他在一次**精神崩潰**後請假休息。

Practice 2

> The phrase **nervous breakdown** is common in everyday speech but is not a precise medical diagnosis.

nervous breakdown 這個說法在日常英語很常見，但並不是精確的醫學診斷名稱。

MCQ-ready definition:

nervous breakdown = informal: 因極大心理壓力而暫時無法正常生活或工作的狀態

Important distinction 1: **nervous** vs **worried**

nervous

often linked to:

- * anticipation
- * performance
- * uncertainty
- * immediate pressure

worried

broader concern about a problem or possible bad result.

> nervous before an interview

面試前緊張

> worried about money

擔心金錢問題

There is overlap, but **nervous** often feels more immediate and bodily.

Important distinction 2: **nervous vs anxious**

Very close.

nervous

common everyday word for temporary tension.

anxious

can mean stronger worry or more persistent unease; in some contexts it can also mean **eager**, though that use can be ambiguous.

> nervous before a speech

演講前緊張

> anxious about the future

對未來感到焦慮

Important distinction 3: **nervous vs scared / afraid**

nervous

usually milder and often about uncertainty.

scared / afraid

more directly about fear.

In your passage, the speaker is not really frightened of the mother; he is **nervous** about her reaction.

Important distinction 4: **nervous vs shy**

nervous

temporary emotional state.

shy

personality/social tendency.

A confident person can still be nervous before a presentation.

Important distinction 5: **nervous vs stressed**

nervous

often anticipatory.

stressed

usually pressure from workload, problems, demands, etc.

> nervous before an exam

考試前緊張

> stressed because of too much work

因工作太多而有壓力

Important distinction 6: **nervous vs excited**

Both can involve similar physical feelings:

- * faster heartbeat

- * restlessness

- * butterflies

But:

nervous

focuses on uncertainty/worry.

excited

focuses on positive anticipation.

A person can be **both nervous and excited**.

Important distinction 7: **be nervous about vs be nervous of**

nervous about

usually concern about an event/situation.

> nervous about the interview

對面試感到緊張

nervous of

often fear or wariness toward a thing/person/activity.

> nervous of dogs

怕狗

This distinction is useful but not absolute.

Important distinction 8: **nervous = emotional vs nervous = neurological**

Emotional

> I'm nervous.

我很緊張。

Biological

> nervous system

神經系統

These are completely different branches in learner terms.

Important distinction 9: **nerves vs nerve**

nerves

often = nervousness

> calm your nerves

讓自己鎮定下來

nerve

can = courage

> find the nerve

鼓起勇氣

a nerve

can also = physical nerve

> damage a nerve

損傷神經

Context changes everything.

Important distinction 10: **have the nerve vs have nerves**

have the nerve to...

= 竟敢 / 有膽量做.....

have bad nerves / suffer from nerves

= 容易緊張焦慮

These are very different.

Important distinction 11: **lose your nerve vs get nervous**

get nervous

become anxious.

lose your nerve

become too frightened to continue with something you intended to do.

> I got nervous before speaking.

我演講前緊張起來。

> I lost my nerve and cancelled.

我最後失去勇氣，取消了。

Important distinction 12: **nervous breakdown**

This is an everyday phrase, not a precise clinical diagnosis.

It should not be automatically equated with one specific psychiatric condition.

For learner purposes:

nervous breakdown = 因心理壓力大到暫時無法正常應付生活的非正式說法

Family-extension note

The family has three major semantic branches:

1. **anxiety / tension**

- * nervous
- * nervously
- * nervousness
- * nerves
- * a bundle of nerves

2. **physical nervous system**

- * nerve
- * nervous system
- * nervous tissue

3. **courage / boldness**

- * find the nerve
- * lose your nerve
- * keep your nerve
- * have the nerve

And one important idiom:

4. **irritation**

- * get on someone's nerves

This is a lovely polysemy family because **nerve** moves from the body's physical nerve fibres to metaphorical emotional steadiness, courage, and irritation.

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea	
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nervous	緊張的；不安的	temporary anxiety	
nervous about X	對 X 緊張	anticipation	
nervous of X	對 X 害怕 / 有戒心	fear/wariness	
nervous person	容易緊張的人	temperament	
nervous smile	緊張的笑	anxiety shown physically	
nervous habit	緊張小動作	anxiety behaviour	
nervous system	神經系統	biology	
nervously	緊張地	manner	
nervousness	緊張；焦慮	state	
nerves	緊張情緒	anxiety under pressure	
bundle of nerves	緊張得不得了	extreme anxiety	
nerve (body)	神經	physical nerve	
nerve (courage)	勇氣；膽量	bravery	
find the nerve	鼓起勇氣	become brave enough	
lose your nerve	失去勇氣；退縮	courage fails	
keep/hold your nerve	保持鎮定	courage under pressure	
have the nerve to	竟敢；厚着臉皮	boldness, often critical	
get on someone's nerves	令某人很煩	irritation	
nervous breakdown	精神崩潰	informal severe distress	

For your original sentence

> I was a bit **nervous** before she opened it, because it felt much more personal than the usual things I would buy.

Here:

nervous = 因為不確定媽媽看到這份很個人的禮物後會有甚麼反應，所以感到有點緊張、忐忑

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> 在她打開之前，我其實有點**緊張 / 忐忑**，因為這份禮物比我平時買的東西私密和個人得多。

The best nuance here is probably **「忐忑」** rather than strong **「害怕」**: the speaker cares about the mother's reaction and feels emotionally exposed, but is not describing actual fear.